



GDD 36 Decoded

Read the machine. Decode anything. Grow.

The media-literacy finale for ages 15-18, and the summit of the whole journey. The feed is engineered to use you, but you can learn to read it and use it instead. Decode the machine (algorithms, the attention economy, filter bubbles), decode the influence (misinformation, AI fakes, scams, dark patterns), decode pornography (gated, non-explicit: it's a performance, not real, not sex-ed), decode yourself (digital wellbeing), then synthesise it all into one "decode anything" habit, and close on Unlearn, Relearn, Grow. A game about manipulation that uses no dark patterns. Seven mechanics, 23 choice-and-voice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Read the machine. Decode anything.

Decoded is the media-literacy finale and a synthesis of the whole fifteen-year journey. It teaches near-adults to decode the information world they're about to inherit as full citizens: to read the algorithms that shape their feeds, see through manipulation and AI fakery, think critically about what they see online (including pornography, handled gated and non-explicit), and build a healthy, intentional digital life, and then it steps back to help them reflect on who they've become. Its central idea is agency: the feed is engineered to use you, but you can learn to read it and use it instead. It moves beyond spotting individual fakes (Reality Check, g28) to understanding the system, and because it closes the journey, it carries the app's core principle, Unlearn, Relearn, Grow, for life. New v2 build.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g36 · decoded (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 5 · ages 15-18 · critical / empowering / non-cynical
Thread / topics	G · Values, Rights & Media · UNESCO 5.4, 4.3, 5.1, 5.6, 2.1, 2.3, 1.1 (KC7)
Prerequisite / builds on	g42 (Life Ready) · builds on g28 (Reality Check), g12, g17 · precedes the c5 capstone
Gating	Gated · non-explicit (school-comfort toggle gates the pornography-literacy module)
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the media-literacy finale.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

16

myth-flips

23

choice & voice

0%

binary taps

The feed is designed to use you, unless you can read it. The deepest media-literacy idea, saved for last, is that the feed itself is engineered: platforms are built to maximise engagement, so what a young person sees is selected to keep them scrolling, creating filter bubbles that quietly shape their view of the world. Understanding the system, not just the individual fakes within it, is the leap from media-literate to digitally wise, and it hands every young person a "decode anything" habit they carry for life.

Critical, not cynical.

From the Chapter 5 personas (15-18). Near-adults stepping into full digital citizenship, who need to read the information world clearly, look after themselves and others online, and keep learning, without tipping into paranoia or doom.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Every teen	To read the machine, why they see what they see, and use it on purpose.	spot + sort : decode the algorithm.
Veer, 17	To drop "I'm too smart to be manipulated" and learn the techniques.	strike-rewrite + spot : decode the influence.
Vijay & Sneha	To decode pornography critically, no shame, and protect body image.	strike-rewrite + role-play : gated, non-explicit.
The Counsellor	To route comparison, low mood and live distress to real support.	branch + reflect : decode yourself.

Why this works (the evidence). Recommendation algorithms and the attention economy are built to maximise engagement, so feeds aren't neutral; they create filter bubbles and reward outrage, and everyone is targeted by manipulation (misinformation, AI fakes, propaganda, scams, dark patterns), which only works while it stays invisible. Pornography literacy for older teens, kept strictly non-explicit, builds critical thinking and reduces shame: pornography is staged performance, not real sex, not a relationship model and not sex education, it sets unrealistic standards and often shows no real consent, and teens' still-maturing minds are more vulnerable to its portrayals, so the move is to think critically and contrast it with healthy, accurate information. Decoding yourself, attention, comparison, privacy and footprint, matters as much, framed as balance, not abstinence.

Seven moves, led by decoding.

It's a critical-thinking game, so **branch** leads (decode a feed, a claim, a habit, a choice), with **strike-rewrite** clearing the comfortable myths and **spot** reading the machine. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE YOUNG PERSON DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (decode it) signature	Decodes a feed, claim, habit or choice and picks the wise move.	Agency in action.	17
strike-rewrite	Busts a comfortable myth ("I'm too smart"; "porn is real").	Conceptual change.	16
reflect	Internalises the lesson and the journey: Unlearn, Relearn, Grow.	Self-efficacy; meaning.	15
sort	Sorts engineered vs neutral; manipulation vs reliable; healthy vs not.	The line.	13
spot	Spots the dark pattern, the attention-capture design, the decoded move.	Reading the machine.	9
match	Pairs an influence type to its tell; a Decoder question to what it uncovers.	Connections.	8
role-play (voice)	Stops a friend forwarding a fake; reassures a friend, no shame.	Voice; kindness.	6

23 of 84 moments are branch or role-play. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**. Reflect kept to 18% so decoding leads.

The two-test, passed.

Is it fun?

Game feel is sharp, satisfying and, at the close, moving. The "decode" reveal, peeling back a glossy feed to show the machinery and incentives underneath, is the signature thrill; an "x-ray on the algorithm" visual language makes the invisible system visible; and the finale is a genuinely reflective, earned send-off rather than just a final level. Sam appears fully grown, a quiet marker that the player has grown up alongside them, and the theme lifts at the end. Crucially, a game about manipulation uses none, no dark patterns, no addictive loops, ever.

Is it teaching?

Yes: how algorithms and the attention economy shape what you see (filter bubbles, engagement incentives); how to decode misinformation, AI fakes and deepfakes, propaganda, scams and dark patterns; how to think critically about pornography (gated, non-explicit: it's a performance, not real, not sex-ed, unrealistic, no shame); how to build healthy, intentional digital habits around attention, comparison, privacy and footprint; and how to synthesise it all into one "decode anything" habit, then reflect on your own growth as a lifelong unlearner and relearner.

The belief it moves. From "my feed just shows what's popular and true; I'm too smart to be manipulated; porn shows what real sex and bodies are like; once you grow up you stop needing to question media" → "the feed is engineered for engagement; everyone is targeted and the technique is the defence; porn is a performance, not real and not sex-ed; and decoding is a lifelong habit I now carry myself."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across the algorithm → influence → pornography → yourself → the Decoder → Grow arc, evidence-based and India-grounded, non-explicit throughout. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Decode the algorithm	14	spot, sort, strike-rewrite	Engineered feeds, the attention economy, filter bubbles.
Decode the influence	16	strike-rewrite, spot, branch	Misinformation, AI fakes, propaganda, scams, dark patterns.
Decode pornography (gated)	14	strike-rewrite, sort, role-play	Performance not real, not sex-ed, unrealistic, no shame.
Decode yourself	14	branch, sort, reflect	Attention, comparison, privacy, footprint; balance not abstinence.
The Decoder (signature)	12	branch, match, spot	Decode anything: source, intent, algorithm, manipulation, truth.
Grow: the journey	14	reflect, match, branch	Unlearn, Relearn, Grow; the digital-life charter; for life.

The 'too smart' flip + a pornography-literacy flip, verbatim.

```
flip: "I'm too smart to be manipulated online."
UN -> "I'm too smart to be manipulated."
RE -> "Everyone is targeted; manipulation works precisely while it stays invisible."

flip: "Pornography shows what real sex and real bodies are like." (gated, non-explicit)
UN -> "Pornography shows what real sex and bodies are like."
RE -> "It's staged performance with edited, unrealistic bodies and acts, not real life."
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 36 Decoded — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game flips.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
My feed just shows me what's popular and true.	It's engineered to maximise your engagement, not to inform you.	Attention economy.
A filter bubble doesn't really affect what I think.	Seeing mostly one kind of view quietly narrows and hardens your sense of the world.	Filter bubbles.
I'm too smart to be manipulated online.	Everyone is targeted; manipulation works while it stays invisible.	Manipulation.
If a video looks real, it's real.	AI can make convincing fakes; verify the source, don't trust the look.	Deepfakes.
Pornography shows what real sex and bodies are like.	It's staged, edited performance, not real sex or real bodies.	Porn literacy.
Porn is a fine way to learn about sex and relationships.	It isn't sex education; it often shows no real consent, communication or care.	Porn literacy.
If you've watched it, something's wrong with you.	Curiosity is normal; no shame, what matters is thinking critically.	No shame.
Once you grow up, you stop needing to question media.	Decoding is a lifelong habit; the techniques keep evolving, so you keep reading.	Lifelong skill.

The micro-loop.

1. **Surface.** Sam (grown) surfaces a feed, a claim, or a habit to examine.
2. **Decode.** The young person decodes the machine, the message, or themselves.
3. **The flip.** UN clears a comfortable myth; RE writes the durable truth; the decoder skill grows.
4. **Synthesise.** The Decoder, who made it & why, how the algorithm served it, what's the manipulation, what's true, how I'll act, on anything.
5. **Grow.** UN & RE's final, reflective appearance; a personal digital-life charter; anonymous Q&A.
6. **Sticker.** The Decoder badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the **"decode" reveal** and the **x-ray on the algorithm**. It is the summit of the media thread, Smart Screen Heroes (g12), Flip the Script (g17) and Reality Check (g28), and synthesises the critical thinking woven through every game, closing the 3-18 journey before the c5 capstone. UN & RE make their final appearance, not to bust one more myth, but to hand the skill over for life.

Critical, empowering, honest.

- **Critical, not cynical.** Builds healthy scepticism and agency while affirming the real good in digital life, never paranoia or doom.
- **Models healthy design.** A game about manipulation that contains no dark patterns, no addictive loops and no engagement-maximising tricks.
- **Pornography module: gated & non-explicit.** Behind a school-comfort toggle; it teaches media literacy about pornography (performance, not real, not sex-ed, no shame), never showing or describing explicit content.
- **Wellbeing-first.** Promotes intentional use, attention and mental health; reinforces the body-image and comparison work of earlier games; routes low mood and distress to support.
- **Reflective close, gently handled.** The journey reflection is warm and optional in depth; no pressure, just a meaningful send-off.
- **Distress-aware Q&A.** Anonymous questions are vetted; anything signalling harm, exploitation or distress is routed to support.
- **Access & privacy.** Audio, offline, low-end build; the charter, reflection and Q&A are on-device and never tied to an identity (DPDP-aligned).

Get help & report (India). A trusted adult / teacher / counsellor · for accurate information on sex and relationships, a doctor or a trusted health service · mental-health support via Tele-MANAS 14416 · report online abuse, deepfakes, scams or non-consensual images at cybercrime.gov.in or the helpline 1930 · Childline 1098 · emergency 112. Educational and media-literacy content only; non-explicit.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. decoded** — `node.game === GameDone key === registry id` (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema**. `type + typed payload`; the **branch** decode-it move leads, with **strike-rewrite** flipping the comfortable myths.
- **Gated & non-explicit**. The pornography-literacy module sits behind a school-comfort toggle and is strictly non-explicit; flagged for media-literacy and CSE expert review.
- **Fact-checked content**. Attention-economy / filter-bubble mechanics, deepfake "verify the source", porn-literacy framing (performance, not sex-ed, unrealistic, no shame), and India routes (cybercrime.gov.in / 1930, Tele-MANAS 14416, DPDP) verified this build; re-verify as the landscape shifts.
- **Scorecard-gated**. Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, top mechanic at 20%, 0% binary, 23 autonomy, 16 UN→RE, 6 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run `score_gdd.py` on any edit.
- **Help-resource hook**. Live distress routes via the shared "get help" component (112 / 1098 / Tele-MANAS 14416 / cybercrime 1930 / trusted adult).
- **Tracked**. `build_gate.py` finalize advances g36 to v2 PASS only after order, read, score, audit and artifact gates pass.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): critical, not cynical; no dark patterns, ever; pornography module gated & non-explicit, no shame; wellbeing-first; distress-aware routing; privacy-respecting (DPDP); made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Read the system, not just the lie.** Because the feed itself is engineered to maximise engagement, understanding the algorithm and the attention economy, not just spotting individual fakes, is the leap from media-literate to digitally wise.
- **Critical thinking beats shame.** Since pornography is a performance, not real, not sex-ed, and teens are more vulnerable to its norms, the protective move is to decode it critically and contrast it with healthy, accurate information, with no shame, never to pretend it doesn't exist.
- **Agency, then a habit for life.** Because manipulation only works while invisible and the techniques keep evolving, the durable defence is a "decode anything" habit, and the journey's real lesson is that learning never stops: Unlearn, Relearn, Grow.

Sources: UNESCO ITGSE Key Concept 7 (media & information literacy) and cross-cutting critical thinking; UNESCO, Media & Information Literacy and digital citizenship; pornography-literacy curricula and research for adolescents (the "Navigating Realities" curriculum, 2025, and peer-reviewed porn-literacy programmes) on reducing shame and building critical thinking about unrealistic standards, consent and body image; India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act 2023; the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal cybercrime.gov.in and helpline 1930; Tele-MANAS 14416. Content is media-literacy and educational only, non-explicit, expert-reviewed and kept current. Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 42 games now v2. Next by order: Capstone, Ready for the World (c5).